

Cognitive Distortions Guide

15 Common Thinking Errors in CBT

Cognitive distortions are systematic patterns of biased thinking that can contribute to anxiety, depression, and interpersonal conflict. Learning to identify these patterns is the first step toward healthier thinking.

1. All-or-Nothing Thinking

Seeing things in black-and-white categories with no middle ground.

Example: "If I don't get an A, I'm a total failure."

2. Overgeneralization

Drawing broad conclusions from a single event using words like "always" or "never".

Example: "I always mess things up. Nothing ever works out."

3. Mental Filter

Focusing exclusively on negatives while filtering out all positives.

Example: "Everyone said my presentation was great, but one person yawned—it must have been boring."

4. Disqualifying the Positive

Dismissing positive experiences as not counting for some reason.

Example: "They only said that to be nice. It doesn't really count."

5. Jumping to Conclusions

Making negative interpretations without evidence (mind reading or fortune telling).

Example: "She didn't text back—she must be upset with me."

Cognitive Distortions Guide (cont.)

6. Magnification / Minimization

Exaggerating negatives or shrinking positives out of proportion.

Example: "Making that small mistake was catastrophic" / "That achievement was no big deal."

7. Emotional Reasoning

Assuming your feelings reflect reality.

Example: "I feel stupid, so I must be stupid."

8. Should Statements

Using "should," "must," or "ought" statements that create pressure and guilt.

Example: "I should be able to handle this without help."

9. Labeling

Attaching a global label to yourself rather than describing the behavior.

Example: "I'm a loser" instead of "I made a mistake."

10. Personalization

Taking responsibility for events outside your control.

Example: "My child got a bad grade—I must be a terrible parent."

Cognitive Distortions Guide (cont.)

11. Catastrophizing

Expecting the worst possible outcome in any situation.

Example: "If I fail this test, I'll never get a job and my life will be ruined."

12. Blaming

Holding others entirely responsible for your emotional pain, or vice versa.

Example: "It's all their fault I feel this way."

13. Fallacy of Fairness

Believing that life should always be fair and feeling resentful when it isn't.

Example: "It's not fair that they got promoted instead of me."

14. Fallacy of Change

Expecting others to change to suit your needs if you pressure them enough.

Example: "If they really loved me, they would change."

15. Always Being Right

Prioritizing being right over the feelings of others.

Example: "I don't care how they feel—I know I'm right about this."

Self-Assessment: Check the distortions you recognize in your own thinking:

☐ All-or-Nothing Thinking

☐ Overgeneralization

☐ Mental Filter

☐ Disqualifying the Positive

☐ Jumping to Conclusions

☐ Magnification / Minimization

☐ Emotional Reasoning

☐ Should Statements

☐ Labeling

☐ Personalization

☐ Catastrophizing

☐ Blaming

☐ Fallacy of Fairness

☐ Fallacy of Change

☐ Always Being Right